

Anisakis simplex hypersensitivity is associated with chronic urticaria in endemic areas.

BACKGROUND: Chronic urticaria (CU) may affect up to 1% of the general population. *Anisakis simplex* hypersensitivity is frequent in areas where raw fish is consumed and *A. simplex* allergy represents a relevant cause of acute urticaria. We assessed the possible association between CU and *A. simplex* sensitization in an area where marinated fish is very frequently eaten. **METHODS:** A thorough history of CU was sought in 919 adults seen at the Allergy Center, Bari. CU patients and 187 controls underwent skin-prick testing with a commercial extract of *A. simplex*, and reactors were recommended a 6-month raw-fish-free diet regimen. Responders were followed after a further 3 months. **RESULTS:** Of 919 subjects, 213 (23%) met the criteria for CU and 106/213 (49.7%) were sensitized to *A. simplex* with a significant difference between patients aged >65 or <65 years (56 vs. 41%, respectively; $p < 0.05$). All patients hypersensitive to *A. simplex* were regular consumers of marinated fish. In a control population without CU, the prevalence of *A. simplex* sensitization was 16% ($p < 0.001$). The 6-month diet regimen led to the disappearance of urticaria in 82/106 cases (77%) versus 1/42 (2%) subjects who did not change their dietary habits ($p < 0.001$). All nonresponders were sensitized to house-dust mites. Of 75 responders who were followed-up after 3 months, CU relapsed in 88% of those who had reintroduced raw fish versus 14% of those who were still on the diet ($p < 0.001$). **CONCLUSION:** In areas where raw or marinated fish is frequently eaten, *A. simplex* hypersensitivity is a frequent cause of CU. Copyright © 2012 S. Karger AG, Basel.